Keeping it Classy

Fatima Sana Shaikh brings restraint and nuance to her cop character in *Hunkkaar: The Roar*



Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Q. You play a police officer for the first time in HotStar Specials' Hunkkaar: The Roar. Isn't it almost like a rite of passage for an actor to don the khaki?

I am glad that it wasn't the stereotypical police officer we always see on screen. ACP Jasleen Singh Soin has more layers, agency and strength. I met officers of different ranks. You generally tend to have a myopic understanding of the system, but my interactions with them changed my perspective. There are some people who want to actually protect you, do what the uniform demands of them.

Q. You've taken a 'less-is-more' approach and your character is stoic and doesn't show her feelings too much.

That's also because when you are the only woman in a roomful of men, you have to choose your words carefully. A woman doesn't have to scream, be rude or angry to be assertive.

Q. The show marks your foray into long-format storytelling. What convinced you that this was the one for your web series debut?

The story was strong and I liked the David vs Goliath theme. All the characters are in search of something. I have never been scared of doing an ensemble show. When there are multiple actors who support each other, I feel something beautiful always emerges.

Q. The sexual assault cases in New Delhi and Jamui shook the nation. What is the significance of a show like *Hunkkaar*, narrating the fallout of a sexual abuse allegation by a minor?

For ages, women have been the first targets when it comes to asserting power. What we need is people in positions of power to have responsibility. I salute the bravery of the boy in Jamui. He is a 17-year-old boy who represents what a man should be.

—With Suhani Singh